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## Become a Growing Church

# Anatomy of Obedience

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Free media and discipleship resources for pastors, leaders, and growing disciples.

# Anatomy of Obedience

*Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit, teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And remember, I am with you always, to the end of the age.*

— Matthew 28:19-20

Jesus' final charge in the Great Commission calls the church to make disciples who obey all that He commanded. This mission raises honest questions for every believer: If salvation is by grace through faith and not by works, why does obedience matter? How do we move beyond inspiration and instruction to actual transformation? And how can we live out this obedience in every sphere of life?

## Saved by Grace, Formed for Obedience



Scripture settles the tension between grace and obedience with beautiful clarity. Ephesians 2:8-10 reminds us:

*God saved you by his grace when you believed... Salvation is not a reward for the good things we have done... For we are God's masterpiece. He has created us anew in Christ Jesus, so we can do the good things he planned for us long ago.*

We are saved by grace alone, through faith alone. Nothing we do earns or maintains this gift. Yet the same passage declares that we are saved *for* good works.

Obedience is not the root of salvation; it is the natural fruit of a life made new in Christ. Genuine faith produces change (James 2:14-26), and love for Jesus is expressed by keeping His commands (John 14:15). Biblical obedience is an act of faith in Christ.

However, obedience is not the goal of the Christian life. It is the means by which we live the abundant life Jesus promised, experience God's presence, participate in His mission, and fulfill the eternal purposes for which we were redeemed. Obedience is the path to Kingdom maturity — to becoming *"a mature person, attaining to the measure of Christ's full stature"* (Ephesians 4:13).

## The Three Essentials of Obedience



We often fail to obey because one or more of the following are not adequately addressed:

### **1. Knowledge — Do I know what Jesus actually commanded?**

You cannot obey what you do not know. Jesus directs us to learn to obey everything He has commanded. These topics cover all aspects of daily life: God, His Kingdom, our identity in Christ, purpose in life, family, relationships, work, money, sex, health, education, government, love, forgiveness, prayer, the church, and more.

### **2. Motivation — Do I desire to obey?**

Informational knowledge is not enough. The heart must want to follow. God's character, Christ's sacrifice and love, our new identity in Christ, the Holy Spirit within us, and the Kingdom of God all move our new hearts to deeper devotional love and desire (Ezekiel 36:26-27; 2 Corinthians 5:14).

### **3. Methodology — Do I know how to obey?**

The Bible gives us both descriptive examples and prescriptive instructions for how to live out God's truths in everyday life. When we are born again, we are spiritual babies. We are no longer of this world, and the ways of this world no longer apply. We must receive clear Kingdom instructions to live as citizens of His Kingdom.

## Exhortation and Teaching



| Exhortation ( <i>The Spark</i> )                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Teaching ( <i>The Blueprint</i> )                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Stirs the heart and appeals to the will.</li><li>• Urges action with passion, encouragement, or warning.</li></ul> <p><b>The Result:</b> Listeners leave highly motivated but completely unequipped, leading to repeated frustration.</p> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Explains truth, clarifies meaning, and equips the hands.</li><li>• Provides practical methodology for specific application.</li></ul> <p><b>The Result:</b> Listeners possess clear steps for daily life when pain is fresh or a habit is entrenched.</p> |

Healthy discipleship preaching refuses to choose. It balances clear knowledge of the command, gospel motivation rooted in grace, and practical steps for daily life.

Jesus and the apostles addressed all three essentials. Paul's letters usually begin with deep doctrinal truths — building knowledge and motivation. Then, with a pivotal *"therefore,"* he transitions and explains at length how to live (methodology).

Much modern preaching leans heavily on exhortation — passionate calls to "obey God!" or "step out in faith!" These feel urgent and emotionally powerful, but without clear teaching on method, listeners leave motivated yet unequipped. They know they should forgive, pray, or resist sin — but not *how*, when the pain is fresh or the habit is entrenched. The result is repeated frustration and, eventually, cynicism.

Discipleship is measured by obedience. Healthy discipleship balances all three essentials: clear knowledge of the command, gospel motivation rooted in grace, and practical steps for daily life.

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